



OBSERVE THE WORDS OF RIGHTEOUSNESS

EARLY LEGAL CODES (2100 BCE–1750 BCE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The first written laws

BEFORE

c. 4000 BCE Uruk, the world's first city, is established in Sumer, Mesopotamia.

c. 3300 BCE Cuneiform, the earliest system of writing, is invented in Uruk.

c. 2334 BCE Sargon of Akkad, a Mesopotamian city-state, conquers Sumer and creates the world's first empire.

AFTER

c. 600 BCE The Book of Exodus echoes Babylonian law by stating “eye for eye” as an element of the law of Moses.

c. 450 BCE The legal basis for retaliation—*lex talionis*—is laid out in the Roman law text, the Twelve Tables.

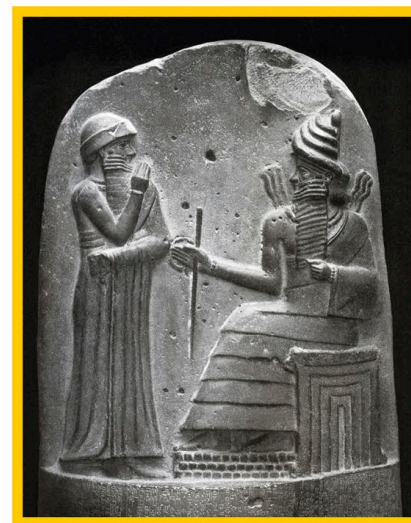
Around 6,000 years ago in Mesopotamia (now Iraq), the Sumerians—the world's first civilization—began to build cities, such as Uruk and Ur, which came to be governed by an *ensi* (king). For people who lived in small farming settlements, the responsibility to avenge wrongs against individuals had rested on families. In cities, large numbers of unrelated people needed to find ways of living and working together peacefully. Laws were therefore invented to resolve disputes and prevent feuds. When city-states grew powerful enough to form the first empires, they issued laws to control peoples spread across their domain.

Keeping a record

Initially, laws were passed on by word of mouth. Around 3300 BCE, the Sumerians began to record information using a writing system called cuneiform (meaning “wedge-shaped”), which consisted of

symbols etched into clay tablets. The earliest surviving cuneiform set of legal rules, or code, was set down by Ur-Nammu, king of Ur, around 2100 BCE. Each law took the form of a stated crime followed by its punishment—for example, “If a man commits a murder, that man must be killed.”

A much more complete code, compiled by Hammurabi, king of Babylon from 1792 to 1750 BCE, was discovered at the start of the 20th century. It is inscribed in cuneiform script on a basalt stele (stone pillar) 7½ feet (2.25 m) high,



The relief at the top of the basalt pillar containing Hammurabi's legal code shows the king standing before Shamash (seated), the Mesopotamian god of justice.